

treatment as there was an infection in his lung and it could be cured faster this way. We never mentioned the word chemotherapy to him.

I booked him into one of the opulent, sea-facing rooms in Breach Candy, and requested the doctors that on no account should he get to know of his ailment. His condition had suddenly taken a turn for the worse and we had to wheel him into his room. I had this sinking feeling that he may not return home.

Surprisingly, he responded well to the first round of treatment, and was able to walk out of the hospital. We did not tell Ma about his condition, and I did not want to tell my brother and sister either. None of them would have been able to handle the news, and my father would have learnt from their faces that he was not going to recover.

I was under tremendous strain those two months. Not only did I have to accompany my father for his treatment, I was also worried that he may get to know about his illness. I knew that at the chemo sessions he would be getting to meet other cancer patients.

One day as we were having dinner, my father suddenly said: 'Cancer is such a dreadful disease.'

I almost choked on my food.

Warily, I asked him: 'Why do you say that?'

'You know, Lala, there were nine of us at the hospital today waiting for treatment. Seven in the group were suffering from cancer. I and another man from Malad were the only ones who did not have cancer. That is when I realized I should not complain to God about anything,' he said. There was little solace in the realization that I was not the only one who was lying to a dying parent.

The market continued to drift lower but I was too distracted to be able to focus my energies on trading. Sensing that my lack of concentration was leading to errors on my part, I kept my positions to the minimum. It was nearly two months since Bauji's treatment had begun, and he was making good progress. In fact, he had become healthier, despite the doctor's verdict that there was no possibility of a complete recovery, I was hoping against hope that he would pull through.

We had another scare, though. Father had to get an X-ray done every time before his chemotherapy. One of the assistants at the lab happened to be the son of Bauji's friend. He asked my father why he was getting X-rays done regularly. My father said he was undergoing treatment for a lung